

THE DA VINCI CODE AND THE GOSPEL ACCORDING TO JUDAS

INTRO: Through the course of history there have been many great battles the Church has had to fight. The most recent has been over the authenticity and nature of scripture. Living in a postmodern age as well as a culture that denies the very existence of any absolute truth, it continues to be a sizeable task for the church to stand firm on the certainty that Scripture is the inerrant word of God. Denominations are fracturing over this very issue. This is nothing new; this battle has been with us for the better part of the last two centuries.

The battle before that was for the nature of the church. From before the Middle Ages up to the reformation the battle centered upon the church itself. The battle was over questions such as:

- Who is really saved?
- How does one get saved?
- How does one become a member of the true church?
- Does one have to go through the Pope or a priest?
- Is each believer a priest unto God?

During this era the Roman church chose a path of exclusivity and claimed that anyone who did not accept their religion was a heretic and should be extinguished. Many of our evangelical forefathers paid with their lives for claiming that the true church consisted, not of those who bowed the knee to Rome, but those who had placed their trust in Jesus Christ, by faith and faith in Him alone.

Before that, during the first few centuries of the Church, the struggle was over the person and work of Jesus Christ. The battle was over questions such as:

- Who was Jesus?
- Was He really God?
- Was He really human?

- How could He be both God and human at the same time?
- Was He born of a virgin, and if so, how could that be?

Because it took faith to accept Jesus as He presented Himself, there were those who wanted to offer alternative explanations for who He was, and what He did. We are facing the same kinds of questions today with regard to the Lord of Glory!

I. THE ANTI-CHRIST IS IN THE WORLD TODAY...

1 John 4:1-3 (NKJV) “Beloved, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits, whether they are of God; because many false prophets have gone out into the world.2 By this you know the Spirit of God: Every spirit that confesses that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is of God,3 and every spirit that does not confess that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is not of God. And this is the spirit of the Antichrist, which you have heard was coming, and is now already in the world.”

In recent days we have begun to hear of a movie which has sold more than 40 million copies and is poised for release on May 19th. This movie is the Da Vinci Code. We have also begun to hear about the discovery of a lost gospel called the Gospel according to Judas. I want to take the next three Sunday mornings and touch on the heretical message being propagated by such blasphemous works.

Several years ago an author by the name of Dan Brown wrote a book called the DaVinci code, on May 19th it will hit theaters around the world as a major motion picture. This movie is directed by Ron Howard and will star Tom Hanks. It is a story which, at a very basic level, seeks to undermine the nature and work of Jesus Christ and thus Christianity as we know it. **With absolutely no historical underpinning, the author makes the following claims:**

- Jesus and Mary Magdalene were man and wife...
- The New Testament is false testimony...
- There were only 80 gospel accounts of Christ's life...
- The Roman emperor Constantine gave us the New Testament...

- The divinity of Jesus is an invention of fourth-century church leaders at the Council of Nicea...

While historians across the religious spectrum have decried Brown for being a revisionist and inventing history to match his fantastic story, the truth of the matter is, most people don't know enough about the Bible or church history to be able to separate fact from fiction.

What about the newly found and world heralded "*Gospel of Judas*?" This recently discovered work depicts the betrayal of the Savior as a cleverly designed conspiracy between Christ and Judas to help Christ to his passion. So what is the problem? It would bring into question the Gospels according to Matthew, Mark, Luke and John! In such a scenario, each believer must decide which gospel writer they are going to believe; on one hand we have Matthew, Mark, Luke and John; on the other hand, the Gospel according to Judas! In an attempt to make a decision we must look at when they were written:

- Matthew A.D. 70-80
- Mark A.D. 50-60
- Luke A.D. 60
- John A.D. 80-100
- Judas A.D. 220-340

The Gospel according to Judas possesses the following problems:

- The science of carbon dating proves it was written more than 220 years after the death of Christ...
- Thirty pages of the writing are illegible...
- The team who worked on this document was able to recreate only 90-95 % of the manuscript...
- The team determined that the author was anonymous...
- The team determined that the document was written with Gnostic lingo... Gnostics believed that the way to salvation was through secret knowledge delivered by Jesus to his inner circle. This knowledge, they believed, revealed how people could escape the prisons of their material bodies and return to the spiritual realm from which they came. This is a doctrine of exclusivity, Jesus always preached inclusiveness! [John 3:16-17](#) (KJV) ***"For God so loved the world, that He gave His only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in Him should not perish, but have everlasting life. 17 For God sent not His***

Son into the world to condemn the world; but that the world through Him might be saved.”

Remember, this document was written 220 years after the death of Judas and Jesus! It was not written by Judas, and could not have been written by an eye witness of the accounts surrounding the cross. Think about this, there was no internet, radio, television, libraries, just word of mouth handed down from generation to generation! Do we really want to rely on a thing with so little collaboration to hang a doctrinal truth on? This would be the equivalent of the following;

- I am going to take information passed down through my family from 220 years ago without one word having been recorded or authenticated for that period of time, and I am going to use it to refute a doctrine solely based on hand-me-down information!!!
- The hand-me-down information I am going to base this on is from 1786!!!
- This information has been passed down from my great, great, great, great grandfather!!!
- This is based on hand-me-down information from ten years after the signing of the Declaration of Independence!!!

A court will not allow hear-say evidence at all!

So, after nearly two millennia, the same old lies about the person and work of Christ which the early church had to put to rest are once again rearing their ugly heads. This should not be a surprise to us; the Word of God accurately predicted this would happen. [Ecclesiastes 1:9](#) (NKJV) ***“That which has been is what will be, That which is done is what will be done, And there is nothing new under the sun.”***

From the very beginning of the church, false prophets have tried to make their way into the church, seeking to draw believers away with half truths and complicated theories. Towards the end of the first century, false teachers were setting forth doctrines contrary to the faith once given to the saints. They were saying *“Jesus was in fact, not God.”* They were claiming *“He was not who He said He was.”* Instead they posed their own theories as to who He was and what He did.

These were the circumstances surrounding the writing of 1st John. The writer here in 1John lets us know that the spirit of Anti-Christ is in the world

and has been since the time that God kicked Lucifer through the goal posts of heaven! [1 John 4:3](#) (NKJV) ***“Every spirit that does not confess that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is not of God. And this is the spirit of the Antichrist, which you have heard was coming, and is now already in the world.”***

I was going to reveal who the Anti-Christ is today but I think she is going to run for President!!! (I’m just kidding!!!)

When I make the statement that the Anti-Christ is in the world today I am speaking of the spirit which will influence the man of sin. The same spirit which will manipulate the Anti-Christ is the same spirit which inspires books and movies like the Da Vinci Code and the same spirit which would attempt to place a book written 300 years after the death of Judas and Jesus on the same level of authenticity as the Canon of Scripture.

I am not refuting that the gospel according to Judas is a real book; I just take exception to it being placed at the same level of believability as the Bible. Something written in the third person 300 years after the fact can tend to be a little foggy! [The spirit of Anti-Christ does several things:](#)

- [It will not allow for His virgin birth...](#)
- [It will not allow for His sinless life...](#)
- [It will not allow for the infallibility of Scripture...](#)
- [It will not allow for His sacrificial death...](#)
- [It will not allow for His miraculous resurrection...](#)
- [It will not allow for His ascension...](#)
- [It will not allow for His second coming...](#)

As you can see the spirit of Anti-Christ cannot allow for any of the things upon which our faith is built. If there are allowances for these things then one must admit that He was and is the Son of God!

I am going to go out on a limb here and make a very bold statement:
“Anyone who does not or cannot embrace the seven things which I just mentioned is either ignorant of the Word or operating in the spirit of Anti-

Christ!” Ron Brown, Ron Howard, and Tom Hanks are either completely ignorant of the facts of the Gospel and its power to save, or they are being influenced by the spirit of Anti-Christ!

It does not matter whether the person or organization is your best friend or your favorite church, if they cannot embrace and take a stand for the seven aforementioned foundational truths then our faith is too weak to stand the test of time and difficulties! Some people would ask, *“If my church embraces four out of seven is that good enough?”* The answer is NO, this is not a top ten list, these are the things Jesus claimed to have fulfilled, which makes Him the Messiah! If these foundational things are eroded then He becomes little more than a prophet or a really charismatic religious leader!

It is time for the church to stand up and be counted! I am calling for a boycott of the film, the book, the distributors, and the actors! The church is going to have to learn to do its talking with its dollars! If this kind of attack was launched against the Koran and Allah these people would all be dead! I do not believe in violence but I do believe the church should vote with its resources! What are you going to do?

II. OVERCOMING THE SPIRIT OF ANTI-CHRIST...

Last week we took an in-depth look at the spirit of Anti-Christ which the writer of our text says is *“Already in the world today...”* Last week we discovered that the spirit of Anti-Christ manifests itself in the following ways:

- It will not allow for His virgin birth...
- It will not allow for His sinless life...
- It will not allow for the infallibility of Scripture...
- It will not allow for His sacrificial death...
- It will not allow for His miraculous resurrection...
- It will not allow for His ascension...
- It will not allow for His second coming...

When we consider the characteristics of the spirit of Anti-Christ and compare it to the DaVinci Code and the Gospel according to Judas one is hard pressed to tell the difference!

With absolutely no historical underpinning the author of the DaVinci Code makes the following claims:

- Jesus and Mary Magdalene were man and wife...
- The New Testament is false testimony...
- There were only 80 gospel accounts of Christ's life...
- The Roman emperor Constantine gave us the New Testament...
- The divinity of Jesus is an invention of fourth-century church leaders at the Council of Nicea...

If we give the Gospel according to Judas the same authority as we do the other four gospels, this would bring into question the Gospels according to Matthew, Mark, Luke and John! In such a scenario, each believer must decide which gospel writer they are going to believe; on one hand we have Matthew, Mark, Luke and John; on the other hand, the Gospel according to Judas! In an attempt to make a decision we must look at when they were written:

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What proof do we have that the seven foundational truths previously discussed are factual?

- **His virgin birth...** Isaiah 7:14 (NKJV) *“Therefore the Lord Himself will give you a sign: Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a Son, and shall call His name Immanuel.”* Luke 1:26-28 (NKJV) *“The angel Gabriel was sent by God to a city of Galilee named Nazareth, to a virgin betrothed to a man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David. The virgin’s name was Mary. And having come in, the angel said to her, “Rejoice, highly favored one, the Lord is with you; blessed are you among women!”*
- **His sinless life...** Hebrews 4:15 (NKJV) *“For we do not have a High Priest who cannot sympathize with our weaknesses, but was in all points tempted as we are, yet without sin.”*
- **Infallibility of Scripture...** The Bible contains 66 books, divided into the Old and New Testaments - 39 in the Old and 27 in the New. The Bible was written by more than 40 authors over a time span of 1500 years. The Bible was written by shepherds, farmers, tent-makers, physicians, fishermen, priests, philosophers and kings; yet it does not contradict itself even once. The Bible has been translated into 2,018 languages, with countless more partial translations, and audio translations - In comparison, Shakespeare, considered by many to be the master writer of the English language, has only been translated into 50 languages. The Bible is still the best seller of all time. From a spiritual point of view the Bible states its own divine inspiration and infallibility: Matthew 5:18 (NKJV) *“**For assuredly, I say to you, till heaven and earth pass away, one jot or one tittle will by no means pass from the law till all is fulfilled.**”* Luke 21:33 (NKJV) *“**Heaven and earth will pass away, but My words will by no means pass away.**”* 2 Timothy 3:16 (NKJV) *“**All Scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness, 17 that the man of God may be complete, thoroughly equipped for every good work.**”* 2 Peter 1:21 (KJV) *“**For the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man: but holy men of God spake as they were moved by the Holy Ghost.**”* Hebrews 4:12 (NKJV) *“For the word of God is living and powerful, and sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing even to the division of soul and spirit, and of joints and marrow, and is a discerner of the thoughts and intents of the heart.”*

- His sacrificial death... Luke 23:33-34,44-46 (NKJV) *“And when they had come to the place called Calvary, there they crucified Him, and the criminals, one on the right hand and the other on the left.³⁴ Then Jesus said, “Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they do.” And they divided His garments and cast lots.⁴⁴ Now it was about the sixth hour, and there was darkness over all the earth until the ninth hour.⁴⁵ Then the sun was darkened, and the veil of the temple was torn in two.⁴⁶ And when Jesus had cried out with a loud voice, He said, **“Father, ‘into Your hands I commit My spirit.’ ”** Having said this, He breathed His last.”*
- His miraculous resurrection... Luke 24:1-7 (NKJV) *“Now on the first day of the week, very early in the morning, they, and certain other women with them, came to the tomb bringing the spices which they had prepared.² But they found the stone rolled away from the tomb.³ Then they went in and did not find the body of the Lord Jesus.⁴ And it happened, as they were greatly perplexed about this, that behold, two men stood by them in shining garments.⁵ Then, as they were afraid and bowed their faces to the earth, they said to them, “Why do you seek the living among the dead?”⁶ **“He is not here, but is risen!** Remember how He spoke to you when He was still in Galilee,⁷ **saying, ‘The Son of Man must be delivered into the hands of sinful men, and be crucified, and the third day rise again.’ ”***
- His ascension... Acts 1:9-11 (NKJV) *“Now when He had spoken these things, while they watched, He was taken up, and a cloud received Him out of their sight.¹⁰ And while they looked steadfastly toward heaven as He went up, behold, two men stood by them in white apparel,¹¹ who also said, “Men of Galilee, why do you stand gazing up into heaven? This same Jesus, who was taken up from you into heaven, will so come in like manner as you saw Him go into heaven.”*
- His second coming... 1 Thessalonians 4:16-18 (NKJV) *“For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first.¹⁷ Then we who are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And thus we shall always be with the Lord.¹⁸ Therefore comfort one another with these words.”*

So how do we overcome the spirit of Anti-Christ? By standing firm on the seven doctrinal truths we have just discussed and not allowing the spirit of error to erode our confidence. [Hebrews 10:35](#) (KJV) ***“Cast not away therefore your confidence, which hath great recompence of reward.”***

[Matthew 24:12-13](#) (KJV) ***“And because iniquity shall abound, the love of many shall wax cold. 13 But he that shall endure unto the end, the same shall be saved.”***

III. REMAINING STEADFAST IN DIFFICULT TIMES...

Last week we ended by talking about staying the course and remaining constant in uncertain times. [Hebrews 10:35](#) (KJV) ***“Cast not away therefore your confidence, which hath great recompence of reward.”*** [Matthew 24:12-13](#) (KJV) ***“And because iniquity shall abound, the love of many shall wax cold. 13 But he that shall endure unto the end, the same shall be saved.”***

We live in times where people and denominations vacillate on the issues. They are all over the charts. Politics in the church causes those who feel their future is dependent on the view others have of them, to wet their finger and hold it up to decide which way the wind of public opinion is blowing before they can make a decision. The word politics is a compound word; poly, meaning many; ticks, meaning blood sucking insects!

I don't think anyone would argue that we are living in the beginning of difficult times for those who claim to believe the doctrinal truths espoused in this series.

The Da Vinci Code and the Gospel according to Judas have once again surfaced some age old questions which centers around two things:

- How do we know the Bible is accurate?
- How do we know the Bible is complete?

The Gospel According to Judas is written in Coptic language. (Egyptian) For some the Gospel according to Judas is the first they have heard about the discovery of “Other” gospels. Many other “*Secret Gospels*” and documents have been discovered over the past century or so. Approximately sixty years ago many similar documents were discovered on the upper Nile River in a village called Nag Hammadi. This is the same general area of the discovery of the Gospel according to Judas. The discovery at Nag Hammadi find

produced about fifty different documents including a number of “*Secret Gospels!*” The “*Secret Gospels*” include:

- The Gospel of Philip...
- The Gospel of Truth...
- The Gospel of Thomas...
- The Gospel of Mary...

Many others were found as well. So how do we know these do not belong in the Canon of Scripture? One of the simple answers is that they are all Gnostic Gospels.

Gnosticism was a religion of redemption that surfaced as early as the late first century A.D. and was popular among some communities through the fourth century A.D. At the heart of [Gnosticism is a belief in two gods](#):

- The creator God to whom we are introduced in Genesis chapter one...
- A secret, hidden, unknown god that exists in the kingdom of light...

It is this unknown god that Gnosticism purports to reveal. At the heart of the Gospel of Judas is a revelation of this unknown god. The Jesus, whom the Gnostics believed in, was very different than the Jesus who is revealed in the Bible.

The Gnostic Jesus did not become incarnate to die on the cross to make atonement for the sin of the world. He came to reveal the higher knowledge about the existence of the unknown god and that every person has a “*divine spark*” of this god within them. According to the Gnostics this “*divine spark*” is trapped in our physical bodies and longs for release from the entombment of the flesh to be reunited with the unknown god in the kingdom of light. They did not believe Jesus died to save us from our sin but to release the god trapped within to a higher level of reality! This sounds a whole lot like what we are hearing in church circles today. This heresy is pretty close to what the new age movement believes!

It is from this kind of belief system that Dan Brown makes his movie which attempts to completely discredit Jesus as the savior of the world! His plot attempts to prove that Judas was doing Jesus a favor rather than betraying

Him. If you believed what the Gnostics believed, this theory would be plausible.

We do not believe this and because of our belief system, which is based on the Canon of Scripture. My question for the Gnostics and Mr. Brown would be that if Judas was acting in collaboration with Jesus' wishes, why did he bring the blood money back and then commit suicide?

Mr. Brown's plot about Jesus marrying Mary Magdalene is derived from a Gnostic passage in *The Gospel of Philip* that says, *"And the companion of the [...] Mary Magdalene, [...] her more than the disciples [...] kiss her on her [...]. The rest of [...]. They said to him, 'Why do you love her more than all of us'"* (The ellipsis [...] indicates where the text is broken away and lost). From this lone partial text, Brown infers that Jesus must have had sexual relations with Mary Magdalene and that she bore children to him. If I was to speak a sentence and leave five fill-in-the-blanks, could you make me say just about anything you wanted me to say?

The Gospel of Philip is also a Coptic text found in Egypt not far from where the Gospel of Judas was discovered. More importantly, they are both Gnostic texts.

The following things are against those who choose to use the Word of God as a rule of faith and practice;

- World opinion...
- Governmental leaders...
- The liberal left...
- Many institutions of higher learning...
- The news media...

We were never promised an easy time of living for the Lord, in fact, quite the contrary is true. *2 Timothy 3:10-16* (NKJV) ***"But you have carefully followed my doctrine, manner of life, purpose, faith, longsuffering, love, perseverance,¹¹ persecutions, afflictions, which happened to me at Antioch, at Iconium, at Lystra—what persecutions I endured. And out of them all the Lord delivered me.¹² Yes, and all who desire to live godly in Christ Jesus will suffer persecution.¹³ But evil men and impostors will***

grow worse and worse, deceiving and being deceived.¹⁴ But you must continue in the things which you have learned and been assured of, knowing from whom you have learned them,¹⁵ and that from childhood you have known the Holy Scriptures, which are able to make you wise for salvation through faith which is in Christ Jesus.”

If we are facing such things how then can we be assured of our steadfastness in difficult times?

1) We must affirm our relationship with God...

The three deadliest enemies of a person attempting to remain steadfast in difficult times are:

- [Not knowing who you are... Romans 8:14-17 \(NKJV\)](#) *“For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, these are sons of God.¹⁵ For you did not receive the spirit of bondage again to fear, but you received the Spirit of adoption by whom we cry out, “Abba, Father.”¹⁶ The Spirit Himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God,¹⁷ and if children, then heirs—heirs of God and joint heirs with Christ, if indeed we suffer with Him, that we may also be glorified together.”* Adopted sons share the same rights and privileges as natural born sons! Slaves were not permitted to use the phrase “*Abba*” because this phrase was reserved for those who were sons. The phrase means daddy! This Scripture basically say’s that Daddy God is my father, and Jesus is my big brother!
- [Not knowing whether He is on your side...Romans 8:31-35 \(NKJV\)](#) *“What then shall we say to these things? If God is for us, who can be against us?³² He who did not spare His own Son, but delivered Him up for us all, how shall He not with Him also freely give us all things?³³ Who shall bring a charge against God’s elect? It is God who justifies.³⁴ Who is he who condemns? It is Christ who died, and furthermore is also risen, who is even at the right hand of God, who also makes intercession for us.³⁵ Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? Shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword?”* [Romans 8:1 \(NKJV\)](#) *“There is therefore now no condemnation to those who are in Christ Jesus, who do not walk according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit.”*

- Not knowing whether He can be trusted... Job 13:15-16 (NKJV)
"Though He slay me, yet will I trust Him. Even so, I will defend my own ways before Him. 16 He also shall be my salvation..."

2) We must affirm our confidence in the Bible as the Word of God... Each person must settle the question in their mind of whether or not they are going to believe the Canon of Scripture to be Gods Word! 2 Timothy 3:16 (NKJV) ***"All Scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness, 17 that the man of God may be complete, thoroughly equipped for every good work."***

3) We must become vocal concerning our beliefs... It is time for those of us who have chosen to believe the Bible to be our only rule for faith and practice to stand up and say so! Psalm 107:1-3 (NKJV) ***"Oh, give thanks to the LORD, for He is good! For His mercy endures forever. 2 Let the redeemed of the LORD say so, Whom He has redeemed from the hand of the enemy, 3 And gathered out of the lands, From the east and from the west, From the north and from the south."*** Matthew 10:32-33 (NKJV) ***"Therefore whoever confesses Me before men, him I will also confess before My Father who is in heaven.33 "But whoever denies Me before men, him I will also deny before My Father who is in heaven."***

4) We must make up our minds to never back down... If we are planning to be victorious we must make up our minds to never back down on what we believe! We will never quit, give up, turn loose, back down, back off, knuckle under, or raise the white flag of surrender!

Once we believe Jesus is who He said He was, we can never be guilty of faltering in our beliefs! Look at who the writer of Philippians said He was. Philippians 2:9-10 (NKJV) ***"Therefore God also has highly exalted Him and given Him the name which is above every name,10 that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of those in heaven, and of those on earth, and of those under the earth."*** Ron Brown, Ron Howard, Tom Hanks and Judas are all going to bow their knee and confess that He is who He said He was!

Listen to what the writer of Ephesians say's with regard to this! Ephesians 1:19-23 (NKJV) ***"...what is the exceeding greatness of His power toward***

us who believe, according to the working of His mighty power²⁰ which He worked in Christ when He raised Him from the dead and seated Him at His right hand in the heavenly places,²¹ far above all principality and power and might and dominion, and every name that is named, not only in this age but also in that which is to come.²² And He put all things under His feet, and gave Him to be head over all things to the church,²³ which is His body, the fullness of Him who fills all in all.”

CONCLUSION: It matters little what authors and movie makers say or think, He is still Lord and our lives are in His hands. If my life is in His hands I feel very confident about the future! [Psalm 91:9-16](#) (NKJV)

“Because you have made the LORD, who is my refuge, Even the Most High, your dwelling place, 10 No evil shall befall you, Nor shall any plague come near your dwelling; 11 For He shall give His angels charge over you, To keep you in all your ways. 12 In their hands they shall bear you up, Lest you dash your foot against a stone. 13 You shall tread upon the lion and the cobra, The young lion and the serpent you shall trample underfoot. 14 “Because he has set his love upon Me, therefore I will deliver him; I will set him on high, because he has known My name. 15 He shall call upon Me, and I will answer him; I will be with him in trouble; I will deliver him and honor him. 16 With long life I will satisfy him, And show him My salvation.”

[Psalm 37:23-25](#) (NKJV) *“The steps of a good man are ordered by the LORD, And He delights in his way. 24 Though he fall, he shall not be utterly cast down; For the LORD upholds him with His hand. 25 I have been young, and now am old; Yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken, Nor his descendants begging bread.”*